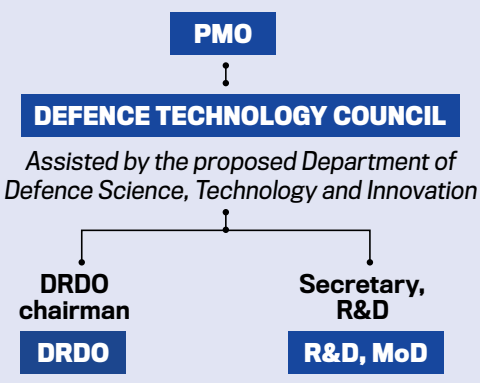


AND AND CONTROL

PROPOSED



DRDO role to be limited to R&D. Start-ups, academic institutions to also do R&D. Production/ further development to be given to private defence industry/ PSUs

and taken on too many projects. Reforming the DRDO is central to the government's plans to boost defence manufacturing—and reduce India's over-reliance on imports—through initiatives such as Aatmanirbhar Bharat as well as giving a fillip to defence exports, where it has set an ambitious target of Rs 35,000 crore by 2025.

The report calls for innovative research where the Army has a greater say than before. DRDO will also be under the PMO's oversight

Several expert committees—like the A.P.J. Abdul Kalam Committee (1992), P. Rama Rao Committee (2008) and the V. Ramagopal Rao Committee (2020)—attempted to right the situation by suggesting measures to make the DRDO a more professional organisation with high accountability. Then, in August 2023, the Narendra Modi government set up a panel headed by former principal scientific advisor VijayRaghavan and tasked it with ensuring focus on research and development of high-end futuristic technologies, maximise academia/ start-ups and private sector participation to develop an indigenous defence production industry.

VijayRaghavan submitted the report, titled 'Redefining Defence Research and Development', to Union defence minister Rajnath Singh. Some of the structural changes the panel has recommended have displeased a group of senior scientists at the DRDO, who have shown their dissent by submitting a response to Singh by expressing doubts about the feasibility of some of the recommended steps. In fact, a group of top defence scientists have reportedly sought an audience with the Prime Minister's Office (PMO)—the ultimate arbiter in the matter—to share their views on the report.

Though there is no quarrel about the overall aim of the report—to cut flab in the organisation and make it an efficient and agile R&D organisation with faster turnover of cutting-edge projects—it is in the methods proposed to obtain the final results that disagreements have arisen.

Of the major steps put forward, the merger of various DRDO labs for greater efficiency appears to have gained the approval of DRDO scientists. But several other suggestions are being resisted by the defence scientists' fraternity.

BONES OF CONTENTION

Among the chief points of dispute is the proposal to bring the DRDO under the purview of the PMO. Also, that the armed forces should have a greater say in the DRDO's development of technologies—the panel feels the organisation has been taking on defence projects that overstretch it, causing massive delay and wastage of resources. Differences have also arisen over a change in the way staff is recruited. Instead of direct recruitment, as is the current practice, the panel recommends campus hiring through interviews. But the issue that has elicited the strongest disagreement is the firm direction in the report towards a much greater role for the private defence sector.

Given the classified nature of the report, the MoD has not reacted publicly after receiving the scientists' letter. The ministry is expected to talk with all stakeholders, resolve all issues and present